THE NEXT 100 ENTREPRENEURS



SAMYUKTA LAKSHMI/GETTY IMAGES

RITESH AGARWAL, 28

Founder & Group CEO, Oyo Rooms, **Gurugram**

Room to Grow

"Ritesh has not only created value for himself but built an ecosystem. His start-up is competing with the best in the world and taking the India story to the next level"

ADITYA MALIK
Senior Partner, Lumis Partners

In 2020, London-based research group Hurun featured Ritesh Agarwal as the second youngest billionaire in their Global Rich List 2020. The founder of Oyo Rooms, though, had become a rage in India long ago. A college dropout from Rayagada in Odisha, Agarwal has built an empire of over a million rooms in 43,000 hotels and 150,000 vacation homes globally. OYO was valued at $10 billion (Rs 75,800 crore) in 2019 after Agarwal bought back shares worth $2 billion (Rs 15,125 crore) from venture capital firms Sequoia Capital and Lightspeed Venture Partners. His start-up success has had its share of ups and downs. Oravel Stays, the budget accommodation platform he had launched in 2012 while in college in New Delhi, had sunk without a trace. Agarwal, at one point, was left with just Rs 30 and the option of returning home. But his entrepreneurial zeal pushed him to not give up. The same spirit helped OYO survive the demand slump during the pandemic. The company invested heavily in technology, restructured operations and went lean. In October 2021, Oyo filed a red herring prospectus with SEBI, seeking clearance to raise Rs 8,384 crore by listing the stocks. The stock market bells are expected to ring in early 2022. ■

–Anilesh S. Mahajan

HOME TRUTHS Agarwal's parents did not believe OYO Rooms was a phenomenal success until they heard Prime Minister Narendra Modi talk about it in one of his radio broadcasts